MALNUTRITION

MEAL STORM IN GUJARAT

By Jumana Shah

In the last week of July, tragedy struck Ludbai village in the Nakhatrana taluka of Gujarat's Kutch district when five children lost their lives. The village's sarpanch, Jabbar Jat, attributed the deaths to malnutrition, spotlighting the dire state of affairs. However, Shailesh Prajapati, the district development officer, linked only two of the deaths to malnutrition. This grim incident gained significant coverage in the local media and underscored a disturbing revelation from the NITI Aayog's Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI) report released just two weeks prior: a staggering 38 out of every 100 children in Gujarat suffer from malnutrition.

This comprehensive index—in its second iteration following the 2021 edition—assesses the severity of poverty across states and districts based on three critical dimensions: health and nutrition, education, and standard of living. According to the report, which relies on data from the National Family Health Survey (NFHS), Gujarat managed to marginally reduce its poverty rate from 18.5 per cent in 2015-16 to 11.7 per cent in 2019-21. The state also managed to reduce its malnutrition rates from 41.37 per cent to 38.09 per cent in the same period, but the improvements fall short when compared to the states with similar GDPs and the efforts invested in addressing the nutritional needs of children.

Gujarat has long been hailed for its commendable per capita income (PCI), consistently exceeding the national average. According to 2021-22 estimates, the state's PCI is Rs 2.5 lakh per annum as against the national average of Rs 1.72 lakh. Back in 2012, when the BJP began touting Gujarat as a "model of development", analysts delved into what that bullish motto might have concealed, and uncovered subpar nutrition levels among children and distressing infant and maternal mortality rates. And the state administration responded with a series of programmes aimed at combating stunting, a manifestation of malnutrition among schoolchildren. A review of these initiatives aimed at the prevention, monitoring and mitigation of malnutrition indicates that the state is not lacking in the availability of schemes—on paper at least. Yet, the NFHS data paints a troubling picture: the share of children aged 6 to 9 suffering from anaemia surged from 62.6 per cent in 2015-16 to a staggering 79.7 per cent in 2019-21. This deficiency is the result of both an inability to afford nourishment and a lack of awareness about its importance. Collectively, these factors have become a heavy burden for the impoverished, preventing them from breaking free from the cycle of poverty.

Confronted with the stark revelations of the MPI report, government officials offer a different perspective. A senior health department official, on the condition of anonymity, disassociates poverty from malnutrition. "People are inclined towards processed packaged foods that are high in calories but lacking in nutritional value.



38
out of every 100 children in Gujarat suffer from malnutrition

11.7%
Rate of poverty recorded in 2019-21, down from 18.5% in 2015-16

79.7%
The share of children aged 6 to 9 suffering from anaemia in 2019-21, up from 62.6 per cent in 2015-16

50%
Children who are not breastfed within the crucial first hour of birth

24.9%
Women aged 20 to 24 who were married before reaching the legal age of 18

Sources: NITI Aayog's Multidimensional Poverty Index; National Family Health Survey